

Common suffixes that form adjectives include: **-able** (comfortable), **-al** (musical), **-y** (cloudy), **-ous** (famous) and **-ive** (attractive).

A

-al

Adjectives ending **-al** are usually formed from nouns, and often mean 'relating to the noun', e.g. a **musical** instrument (from music), a **political** issue (from politics), an **electrical** fault (related to electricity), a **personal** opinion (the opinion of one person).

SHICHI-GO-SAN

Shichi-Go-San (meaning 7, 5, 3) is an **annual** ceremony in Japan for three-and seven-year-old girls, and three-and five-year-old boys. It is on November 15, but it is not a **national**¹ holiday, so people often have it on the nearest weekend. Seven, five and three are seen as important years in the growth of a child, and the numbers also have **cultural significance**² because odd numbers (1, 3, 5, 7, 9, etc.) are lucky in Japan. This is one of the special days when the older boys and girls are allowed to wear **traditional**³ clothes: a kimono for girls and hakama trousers for boys. Now it is quite **normal**⁴ for children to wear western-style clothes at this ceremony. The children visit a shrine and are then given special sweets called *Chitose-Ame* by their parents.



¹ a holiday for the whole country

² they are important in Japanese culture

³ in a style that has continued for many years

⁴ usual

B

-able /əbl/

This suffix forms adjectives from nouns *and* verbs, and the prefix **un-** often forms the opposite: an **enjoyable** party [something that you enjoyed]

a **comfortable** chair (*opp* **uncomfortable**)

a **suitable** word or phrase [right/correct for a particular situation; *opp* **unsuitable**]

a **reliable** service; reliable information [able to be trusted or believed; *opp* **unreliable**]

fashionable clothes [popular now with many people; *opp* **unfashionable**]

a **reasonable** decision or price [fair; not a bad decision or price; *opp* **unreasonable**]

a **sociable** person [enjoys being with people; *opp* **unsociable**]

Sometimes the opposite form is the more common adjective:

an **unforgettable** experience [something that cannot be forgotten]

an **unbelievable** story [something that is very surprising and very difficult to believe]

C

-ful and **-less**

The suffix **-ful** often means 'full of' or 'having the quality of the noun', e.g. a **colourful** room has a lot of colour in it; a **helpful** person gives a lot of help; a **peaceful** place is calm and quiet. The opposite meaning is sometimes formed by adding the suffix **-less** to the noun.

a **useful** machine [having a lot of uses; *opp* a **useless** machine]

a **painful** injection [giving pain and being unpleasant; *opp* a **painless** injection]

a **careful** driver [drives with care and attention; *opp* a **careless** driver]

Common mistakes

The suffix is **-ful** (NOT ~~full~~), so **useful** and **careful** (NOT ~~usefull~~ or ~~carefull~~).